The Terminator

The boundary between light and shadow

The terminator is the line (or zone) on a form where light ends and shadow begins. Its shape and softness reveal the shape of the form, the type of light, and the angle between the form and the light source.

KEY CONCEPTS

What It Tells You

The terminator's shape mirrors the shape of the form it crosses. On a sphere, it's a curve. On a box, it's a hard line at an edge. On a face, it follows the contours of the anatomy. Map the terminator correctly and the form reads.

Hard vs Soft Terminator

Direct, bright light creates a sharp, well-defined terminator. Diffuse light (overcast day, skylight) creates a soft, gradual terminator. The softness of the terminator is one of the primary ways to describe the quality of the light source.

Finding the Terminator

Set up a simple form under a single light source. Look for the line where the surface first turns away from the light. This is the terminator. On a sphere, it's not at the edge — it's roughly 70–80% across from the light.

The Core Shadow

Just inside the terminator is often the darkest area of the form — the core shadow. This is where neither direct light nor reflected light reaches. It's typically not at the very edge of the form, but just inside the shadow side.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a sphere with clear terminator — notice it's not at the silhouette edge.
2. Draw the same form under 3 different light qualities. Compare the terminator edge.
3. Draw a face and explicitly locate and draw the terminator on each major form.

FURTHER READING

■ **Proko – Terminator & Shadow**
https://youtu.be/V3WmrWUEIJo

■ **Watts Atelier – Light Logic**
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fFwmvzCIXAM